can teach you a hell lot about relationships...how to give and claim space, and show affection without smothering someone," he says. "Cats are dignified, know how to ignore you and know their place in your life." In *Max, Min and Meowzaki*, the cat—played by desi *billi* Radha—is artfully used to show Max's evolving maturity.

WE ARE FAMILY

Dogs have been woofing about in Hindi cinema for some time. Tuffy ensured Prem and Nisha were matched in *Hum Aapke Hain Koun...!* (1994), and in Santosh Sivan's *Halo* (1996), a seven-year-old girl embarks on an adventure to find her missing pet. But the film that highlighted the cause of street dogs was *Chillar Party* (2011), in which colony kids unite to save their community indie from a corrupt politician who wants to have it killed. Soon, Aamir Khan would lend his voice to Pluto Mehra, the Bullmastiff pet the Mehras travel with in *Dil Dhadakne Do* (2015) and Akshay Kumar would have a dog as his co-star in *It's Entertainment* (2014).

Southern cinema has had its share of canine cast too. Kannada film *777 Charlie* (2022) would show the plight of dogs in breeding units; in Malayalam film *Eko* (2025), an ageing woman uses her rare breed dogs to both protect herself as well as exact revenge, while in Tamil drama *Pariyerum Perimal* (2018), a slender black dog becomes a target of caste-based violence.

For Abodh Aras, CEO of Mumbai-based Welfare of Stray Dogs, what's heartening is how dogs, particularly indie strays, are making their way into cinema. He cites the example of acclaimed Marathi drama *Tighee* (2026), in which a fractured relationship between an ailing mother and her two daughters gets some temporary reprieve after a puppy is rescued and brought home.



MAX, MIN & MEOWZAKI

Director: Padmakumar Narasimhamurthy

What happens when a couple splits and the boyfriend has to look after their pet cat and deal with both allergies and emotional upheaval? Padmakumar's film shows how the furry creature becomes an emotional anchor for the protagonist



KAAPUSKONDA

Director: Sachin Mohite

Sachin Pilgaonkar plays a man who cannot stand dogs but finds himself stuck with one. Despite multiple attempts to abandon it, the dog refuses to let go of the family. Set in rural Maharashtra, the Marathi drama shows how dogs can win over even the most hard-hearted

"It shows the joy of how having a companion like a dog can make you forget hardships," says Aras. "It makes a difference to people's perception of having indies as pets." Aras, though, also emphasises the need for filmmakers to adhere to the Animal Welfare Board of India (AWBI) guidelines while filming.

That's what Anjali Gopalan, member, AWBI, does most Thursdays—deliberating with her colleagues as to which film gets a NOC (no objection certification) with the disclaimer 'No animals were harmed during the making of this film'. For AWBI, pre-shoot permission, which details the storyline and use of animals, is a prerequisite. "We tell them what is acceptable and ask for cuts for scenes depicting animal cruelty, even if it is done using CGI or AI," she says. For *OMD*, Rai followed AWBI guidelines, ensuring that the dogs had anti-rabies shots, a dog trainer was present on set and proper transportation was arranged to take them from Mumbai to Bihar and Assam.

COMPASSION OVER CRUELTY

While Hollywood continues a rich tradition of dogs and cats being integral part of storylines, India is slowly catching up. "In India, we don't have that level of empathy yet," says Padmakumar. But he believes that the 'crystal generation' (those born after 2000) is particularly compassionate towards animals.

It's why Rai feels making *OMD* was necessary, especially when attitudes towards indie strays are exceedingly negative after the Supreme Court's recent judgment ordering the removal of strays from institutional spaces like hospitals and railway stations. "We all are woven in a single thread. It is us humans who started thinking we own this world and created boundaries," he says. "Animals are here to show loyalty and kindness and teach empathy." ■